SIMPLE POSE SKETCHES

Four foundational kata stances & guards

A compact, print-friendly reference for recognizing common karate shapes. Each page highlights one stance with a minimal checklist.

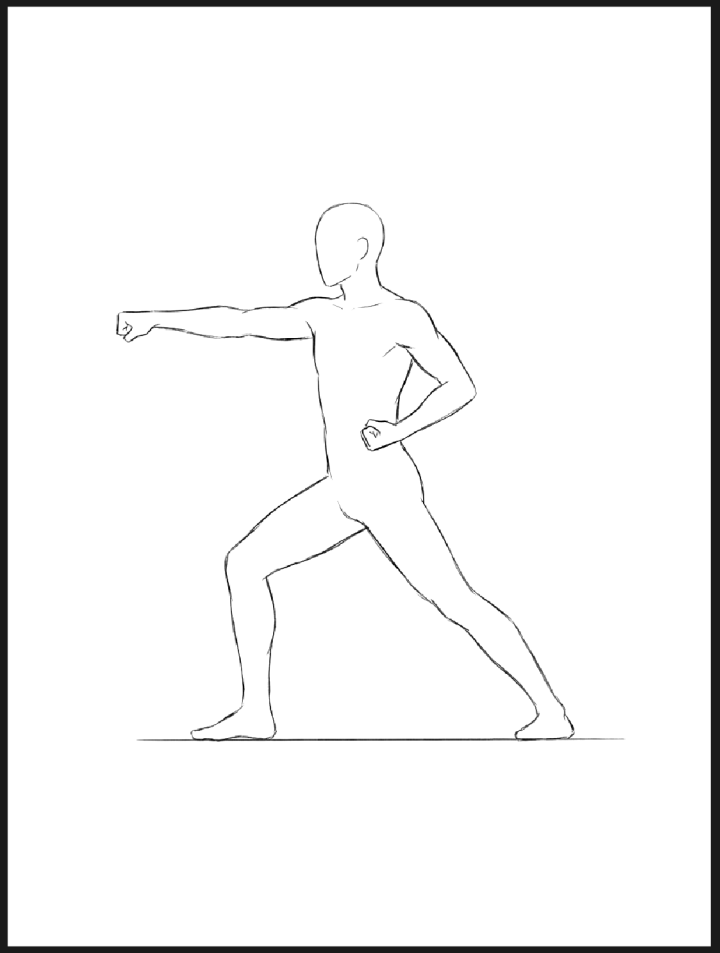
Note: names and mechanics vary slightly by style (Shotokan / Shito-ryu / Wado-ryu / Goju-ryu).

Included poses

- **Zenkutsu-dachi** + Oi-zuki (front stance, lunge punch)
- **Kokutsu-dachi** + Age-uke (back stance, rising block)
- **Kiba-dachi** (horse stance, chambered fists)
- **Neko-ashi-dachi** + Shuto kamae (cat stance, knifehand guard)

HOW TO USE

Compare your silhouette to the sketch first, then check feet, knees, hips, and guard.



STANCE + TECHNIQUE

Zenkutsu-dachi · Oi-zuki

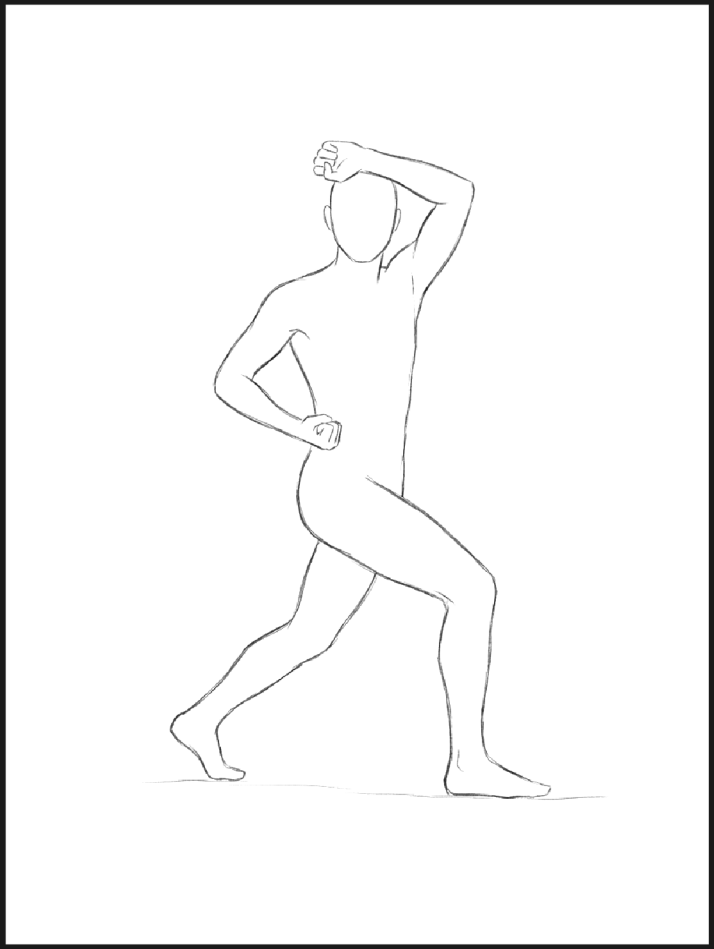
A long forward stance used to drive distance and momentum into a straight punch.

Key checkpoints

- Front knee bent (tracking over toes), rear leg straight and active.
- Hips square-ish to the front; torso upright (no forward collapse).
- Feet on two rails (not a tightrope), stable base front-to-back.
- Front fist punches on centerline; rear fist chambers at the hip.

COMMON FIX

If the stance feels wobbly, widen the stance laterally (two-rail alignment) before making it longer.



STANCE + TECHNIQUE

Kokutsu-dachi · Age-uke

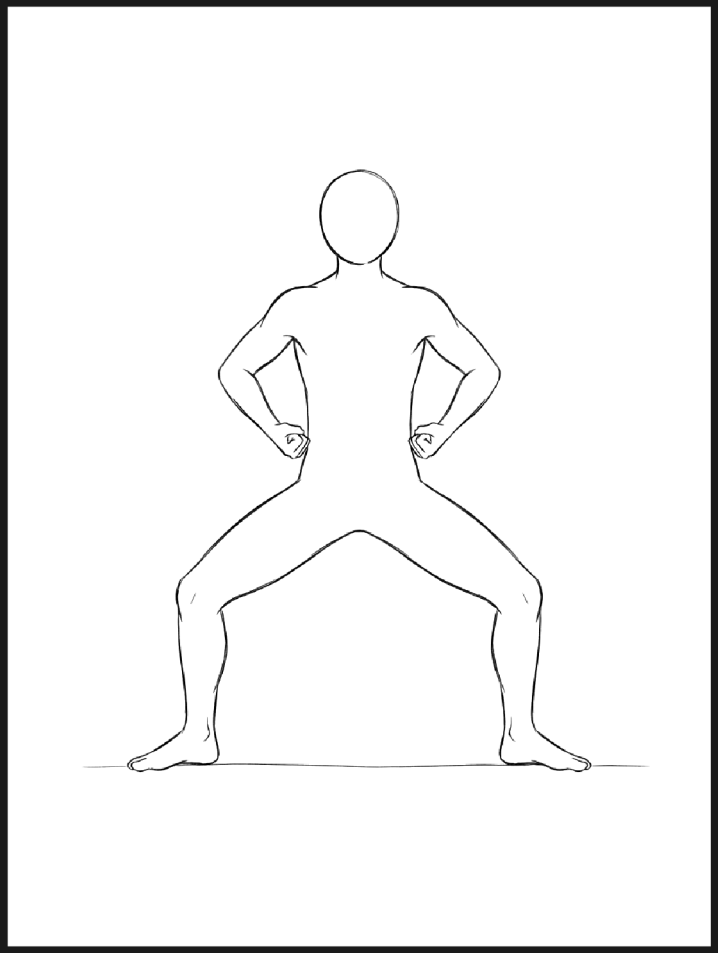
A rear-weighted stance that supports turning and angled defense.

Key checkpoints

- Most weight on the back leg; front foot light and ready.
- Hips and shoulders slightly bladed (not fully sideways, not square).
- Front knee relaxed (not locked); back knee carries the load.
- Blocking forearm rises to protect the head line; other fist chambers.

COMMON FIX

If you drift backward, shorten the stance and keep the torso vertical over the rear hip.



STANCE

Kiba-dachi

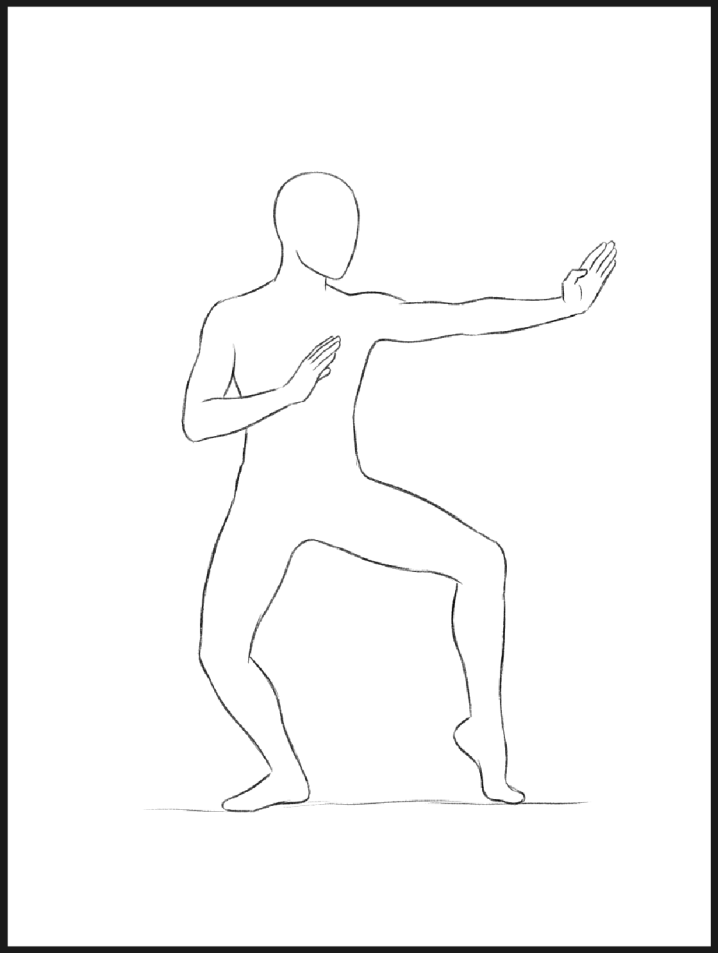
A low, wide stance for lateral stability and hip-driven techniques.

Key checkpoints

- Feet wide; knees push outward in line with toes.
- Pelvis neutral; chest lifted; avoid leaning forward.
- Weight centered; imagine sitting straight down between the feet.
- Elbows back with fists chambered (ready to drive techniques from the hip).

COMMON FIX

If your knees cave in, reduce width slightly and focus on externally rotating the hips.



STANCE + GUARD

Neko-ashi-dachi · Shuto kamae

A compact, rear-weighted stance used for quick shifts, checks, and angled entries.

Key checkpoints

- Back leg carries most weight; front foot touches lightly on the ball.
- Front heel lifted; stance short (ready to step, kick, or slide).
- Torso tall; hips stable (don’t sit too far back).
- Open-hand guard: lead hand extended, rear hand near chest.

COMMON FIX

If the front foot gets heavy, bring your center a few centimeters forward while keeping weight mostly rear.